From the very beginning, Lord Auckland, his sisters and their guests suffered from an enervating imperial ennui born of a patronising – if mildly amused – disdain for the distant colony through which they were forced to pass. On the second day of the trip, Emily remarked that their guests 'were all, like our noble selves, so much bored that they went to bed at eight'. As for her brother, 'G is already bored to death,' she wrote a week into the trip. 'Disgust is turning him yellow.'[72] 'We get on much slower than we expected,' agreed Fanny, 'and George, cut off from his papers and office-boxes and his "members in council" has a sort-of deposed Governor General feel which makes him impatient**?**. . .?He is growing rabid with his tent life, and scolds me every morning because the view is not prettier.'[73] Only the prospect of some parties upstream cheered the sisters: 'invitations to a ball have reached us from Brigadier Richards . . . I fancy this is the beginning of a constant course of dancing we are going through till we reach the Himalayas . . . I think it would be fitting if George would learn to walk through the minuet de la cour. Emily or I could take it in turns to follow with the reigning brigadier of the station . . .' Meanwhile, there was trouble to deal with in the provision department: 'General Casement and Mr Macnaghten came on board this evening. We think there is something wrong with the apple jelly they have had at breakfast. A mysterious allusion was made to it by Mr Macnaghten, which was hastily nipped in the bud by General Casement.'[74]

It was in the midst of such cares that Lord Auckland was forced to turn his attention to matters Afghan.

Afghanistan was a country Auckland knew or cared about even less than he knew or cared about India, and from the beginning he showed a marked antipathy to its most powerful ruler, Dost Mohammad Khan. Dost Mohammad, by contrast, had gone out of his way to court the new Governor General. As soon as he heard of Auckland's arrival he had sent a letter telling him that 'the field of my hopes which before had been chilled by the cold blast of wintry times, has by the happy timing of your Lordship's arrival become the envy of the garden of paradise . . . I hope that your lordship will consider me and my country as your own.'[75] He then came to the point, asking Auckland to intervene on his behalf with Ranjit